

Varun Srivastava

408-896-0580 | varun.neal@berkeley.edu | varunneal.github.io | linkedin.com/in/varun-n-sri

EDUCATION

University of California, Berkeley

B.A. Computer Science, Mathematics

Graduated Dec 2023

GPA: 3.9/4

EXPERIENCE

LLM Pretraining Research

Independent; partially funded

September 2025 – Present

New York, NY

- **Modded-NanoGPT:** Top-3 competitor in the NanoGPT speedrun; eight world records (Sept 2025 – Jan 2026) spanning attention kernels, optimizer modifications, and training-schedule design. Several contributions have since been adopted and cited in subsequent pretraining research.
- Contributor to **NanoChat** (>56,000 stars), which uses my Flash Attention 3 module.
- Optimizer research (including an entry on the NanoGPT optimization leaderboard) and RL environments for autonomous AI research, funded by Prime Intellect; technical writing at varunneal.github.io.

Machine Learning Engineer

AdMarketplace

August 2024 – Present

New York, NY

- Leading training and deployment of the embedding (vector) model powering ad retrieval across all major publishers (such as Yahoo and Firefox), serving 500M+ product titles and driving >\$100M in annual revenue.
- Train and optimize CTR/CPC time-series models for the firm's algorithmic bidding system, directly impacting millions of dollars in daily ad spend allocation.

Founding Engineer

Stork Oracle Network

August 2022 – December 2022

San Francisco, CA

- Designed a high-speed, reliable WebSocket API for live crypto data, serving DeFi clients (Vertex, Apex) trading millions of dollars daily.

Quantitative Analysis Intern

Dexterity Capital

May 2022 – August 2022

Seattle, WA

- Implemented an evolutionary hyperparameter tuning model for the company's proprietary HFT market making algorithm, trading billions in daily volume, accelerating hyperparameter convergence by > 100x.

PUBLICATIONS & SELECTED PROJECTS

Publications | *Berkeley Artificial Intelligence Research (BAIR)*

2024 – Present

- Lee, J., He, J., Smith, B., **Srivastava, V.**, Yuan, T., Geng, I., Hu, K., Tuten, W., Ng, R. "The Hyper-Observer: A Framework for Observer Classification." *ACM SIGGRAPH Asia*, 2026 (conditionally accepted).
- Lee, J., **Srivastava, V.**, Jennings, N., Ng, R. "Theory of Human Tetrachromatic Color Experience." *ACM SIGGRAPH*, 2024. Honorable Mention, Technical Papers Awards.

Spotify MCP | github.com/varunneal/spotify-mcp

- An MCP server allowing LLMs to control Spotify. Winner, Anthropic MCP Hackathon (Nov 2024).

Semantic Finder | do-me.github.io/SemanticFinder

- One of the first in-browser vector search engines, with a companion Chrome extension (>300 stars).

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages & frameworks: Python (PyTorch, JAX, Triton), CUDA, C/C++, Go, SQL.

Systems: Distributed training, AWS, Docker, Kubernetes.